

ECON 101—INTRODUCTION TO MICROECONOMICS

Fall 2020

Department of Economics
Nazarbayev University

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Lecture Delivery Mode: Asynchronous delivery through recorded lectures plus additional group office hours, please see below.

Office hours: By appointment, book weekly at <https://alejandromelo.youcanbook.me> during available slots, please sign at least one day in advance.

Tutorial Sessions: There will be tutorial sessions held approximately every week, except possibly the first one. The tutorials will be lead by one my undergraduate teaching assistants and will be held through the Zoom platform. Each tutorial will be like a Q&A session, in which you will be able to ask questions about past assignments or course materials. You must be enrolled in one of the following.

1. Friday, 10:00 AM–10:50 AM
2. Friday, 11:00 AM–11:50 AM
3. Friday, 01:00 PM–01:50 PM

Course Description The objective of the course is to introduce you to a set of analytical tools, i.e. *the core principles of microeconomics*, needed to understand the functioning of market economies and also to apply those principles to everyday life and understand economic and social phenomena. At the end of the course, the student is expected to apply these tools in the analysis of daily economic problems and to be able to discuss critically economic policy issues. We will study consumer and firms behavior, how different types of markets work, welfare implications of different market structures, international trade, market failures, and public policies.

Course Website All course material and assignments will be posted on the Moodle platform, so it is important that you check regularly.

Course Delivery The mode of the course will be **asynchronous delivery**. This means that we will not hold virtual real time lectures, but instead all of the content will be delivered through prerecorded lectures and reading materials, which will be uploaded to Moodle each week. However, we will hold regular **group office hours**, at a minimum of once every week, so that I can meet with you and go over some questions that you may have about the course material. These group office will be scheduled, in principle, during the official time for the class as posted in the official Registrar's schedule; however, if needed, I will also schedule them at other times which are convenient for a majority of the students.

Textbook The required textbook is **Microeconomics**, by **Robert S. Pindyck & Daniel L. Rubinfeld**, 9th ed. You will be provided, through Moodle, with a pdf version of the book. You should also be able to find printed versions of this edition and earlier ones in the library. You will be responsible from all the material I cover or assign in the recorded lectures. Therefore, studying the textbook is very important but *not* a perfect substitute for the material I cover in the lectures.

Discussion Forum There will be a discussion forum in Moodle in which you will be able to ask questions about the course. I will check regularly the forums. Usually, many students will have the same question, so I will respond to a set of similar questions through a global post of my own.

Grading Policy Grading will be based upon weekly assignments, quizzes, two midterm exams and an optional final two midterm exams, a final exam, and Moodle quizzes/assignments, according to the following weights:

- Assignments (25%)
- Quizzes (25%)
- Midterm I (25%)
- Midterm II (25%)
- Final Exam (25%, optional, replaces lowest midterm score)

There will be *weekly* assignments, except during Midterms week, which you will be able to complete online on Moodle. The purpose of the assignments is to help you learn the material, but most importantly, to learn from your mistakes and learn where are gaps in your knowledge. Therefore, you will be able to submit the assignment a maximum of two times: if the first time you didn't do as well as you expected or wanted, you might resubmit again. After I post an assignment, you will have a few days to submit it.

We will also have regular quizzes, at a rate of one every two weeks approximately. You will also complete your quizzes online on Moodle. Quizzes are meant to assess your progress and to make you study regularly the material. In contrast with assignments, you will be able to submit your quizzes only one time. Also, quizzes will be scheduled to be taken on a particular day and time. Of course, given the nature of online assessments, I will provide you with a large enough window of time during the day of the quizz to submit it.

You will have two midterms, the first one just before the *Registrar's midterm evaluation submission period* and the second one towards the end of the course. Each midterm covers roughly half of the course material and they are not cumulative. These two exams will be deployed though Moodle, similarly to the quizzes. You can think of them as longer and more challenging compared to the quizzes.

Finally, you will have the option to take the final exam, during finals week as scheduled by the Registrar's Office. The final exam is cumulative and will include all the topics in the course. It has the same weight as each midterm, as it is meant to replace one of your lowest midterm' scores. You will only need to take the final exam if you are not happy with any of the grades of the previous midterms and you would like to improve your final score.

A letter grade based on the sum of the components above will be assigned as follows:

Letter Grade	Score Achieved
A	[95, 100]
A–	[90, 95)
B+	[85, 90)
B	[80, 85)
B–	[75, 80)
C+	[70, 75)
C	[65, 70)
C–	[60, 65)
D+	[55, 60)
D	[50, 55)
F	[0, 50)

Course attendance As mentioned earlier, the main mode of delivery is asynchronous, so I will not take regular course attendance. However, I will monitor your Moodle access, so it is important that you check regularly. I will try to make the course as easy as possible to follow by organizing it through the Moodle platform. However, you will have to work extra hard to keep on track with the course material. The group office hours will also serve for me to get an idea of how you are doing. It will be **IMPERATIVE** that you strive to prepare yourself before these office hours, so that you come armed with as many

clear questions as possible. If you need more individualized help, I will be happy to meet you during individual office hours, which can be scheduled through <https://alejandromelo.youcanbook.me> during available slots. Please book at least 24 hours in advance.

Make-up Policy You need to have a valid and documented reason (per university policy) for missing an exam. Do your best not to miss an exam. If you have a valid reason for missing a midterm exam, its weight will be shifted to the final exam.

Rules and Regulations Please turn off laptops, tablets, and mobile phones, unless you are asked to do otherwise. Do not arrive late or leave early without prior permission; Do not engage in side conversations or other disruptive behavior.

Academic Misconduct Academic and personal misconduct by any student in this course will be dealt with according to the requirements and procedures in the Student Code of Conduct for Nazarbayev University. Plagiarism and cheating will not be tolerated. Students should be familiar with the university's official statement on plagiarism: Plagiarism is intentionally or carelessly presenting the work of another as one's own. It includes submitting an assignment purporting to be the student's original work which has wholly or in part been created by another person. It also includes the presentation of the work, ideas, representations, or words of another person without customary and proper acknowledgment of sources. Plagiarism occurs when a person:

1. Directly copies one or more sentences of another person's written work without proper citation. If another writer's words are used, you must place quotation marks around the quoted material and include a footnote or other indication of the source of the quotation. This includes cut and paste from the internet or other electronic sources;
2. Changes words but copies the sentence structure of a source without giving credit to the original source, or closely paraphrases one or more paragraphs without acknowledgment of the source of the ideas, or uses graphs, figures, drawings, charts or other visual/audio materials without acknowledging the source or the permission of the author;
3. Submits false or altered information in any academic exercise. This may include making up data for an experiment, altering data, citing nonexistent articles, contriving sources, etc.;
4. Turns in all or part of assignment done by another student and claims it as their own;
5. Uses a paper writing service, has another student write a paper, or uses a foreign language translation and submits it as their own original work.

These are serious offenses resulting in an F grade and disciplinary action.

Tentative Course Outline

1. Introduction: Basic Concepts and Principles.
2. Specialization and Gains from Trade.
3. Demand and Supply.
4. Elasticity of Demand and Supply.
5. Consumer Behavior and Demand.
6. Firm Behavior and Supply in Perfectly Competitive Markets,
7. Long-Run Equilibrium in Perfectly Competitive Markets.
8. Efficiency and Intervention and Markets.

9. Imperfect Competition.
10. Externalities.
11. Public Goods.
12. Game Theory.
13. Economics of Information.

Disclaimer Subsequent changes can be made to any part of this syllabus when necessary. Any changes will be announced in class and on Moodle.